

Post-Process Theory: Beyond the Writing-Process Paradigm

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1 Introduction

Post-process theory represents one of the most significant epistemological disruptions in the history of composition studies. Emerging in the late 1990s as a sustained critique of the process movement that had dominated writing instruction since the 1970s, post-process theory challenges the foundational assumption that writing can be described as a singular, codifiable, and universally teachable process. Rather than proposing an alternative master framework, post-process theorists argue that no such framework is possible—that writing, as a fundamentally situated, interpretive, and public act, resists the kind of systematization that process pedagogy presupposes. This report examines the intellectual origins of post-process theory, its core philosophical claims, its key figures, its pedagogical implications, and the criticisms and lasting influence it has generated within rhetoric and composition studies.

2 Origins: The Post-Process Moment

The formal articulation of post-process theory is most directly associated with Thomas Kent's edited collection *Post-Process Theory: Beyond the Writing-Process Paradigm*, published by Southern Illinois University Press in 1999. This volume brought together contributors including Gary Olson, Sidney Dobrin, Joseph Petraglia, Barbara Couture, David Russell, and others who shared the conviction that composition studies had reached an impasse in its reliance on process pedagogy as an organizing paradigm. Kent's earlier monograph, *Paralogic Rhetoric: A Theory of Communicative Interaction* (1993), which won the 1995 Conference on College Composition and Communication Outstanding Book Award, laid much of the philosophical groundwork that the 1999 collection would elaborate.

The “post-process moment” did not emerge in a vacuum. By the 1990s, the process movement—inaugurated by figures such as Janet Emig, Donald Murray, Peter Elbow, and Linda Flower and

John Hayes—had achieved near-hegemonic status in composition studies. Writing instruction across American universities had largely organized itself around the stages model of prewriting, drafting, and revision. While this paradigm had been enormously productive in displacing the earlier current-traditional rhetoric with its emphasis on surface correctness and formulaic modes, post-process theorists argued that process pedagogy had itself calcified into a prescriptive orthodoxy. What had begun as a descriptive account of what writers actually do had become a normative framework dictating what writers should do. The process paradigm, in other words, had become precisely the kind of reductive master narrative it had originally sought to overthrow.

3 Core Claims

Post-process theory rests on three interrelated assumptions about the nature of writing, each of which directly contests the premises of process pedagogy.

Writing is public. This is the claim that writing is fundamentally a communicative act situated within social interchange. Writing does not originate in the private cognitive operations of an isolated individual but emerges through and for public discourse. The implication is that the expressivist and cognitivist strands of process theory—which locate writing’s generative center in the writer’s interior life or cognitive architecture—misapprehend the essentially social and dialogic character of written communication.

Writing is interpretive. Meaning in writing is not fixed, stable, or transparently encoded in textual form. Rather, meaning arises through acts of interpretation that are themselves contingent, contextual, and negotiated between writers and readers. No text carries a single determinate meaning; every act of reading is an act of hermeneutic engagement. This claim undermines the process assumption that mastery of certain composing strategies will produce reliably effective texts, since effectiveness is always a function of interpretive contexts that cannot be fully anticipated or controlled.

Writing is situated. Because writing is public and interpretive, it is always produced from a particular position within specific social, cultural, institutional, and rhetorical circumstances. There is no context-free writing, and therefore no context-free writing process. The situated nature of writing means that whatever strategies or heuristics a writer deploys in one situation may prove entirely inadequate in another. Generalizability—the core promise of process pedagogy—is precisely what post-process theory denies.

Gary Olson articulated the overarching consequence of these three claims with particular force. In his contribution to Kent’s collection, “Toward a Post-Process Composition: Abandoning the Rhetoric of Assertion,” Olson argued that the process paradigm attempts to “systematize something that simply is not susceptible to systematization.” For Olson, writing conceived and taught as a

prescriptive and generalizable “process” creates a Theory of Writing—a master narrative that claims universal applicability. Olson further distinguished between theory as a noun, which he regarded as dangerous in its connotation of singular truth, and theorizing as a verb, which he endorsed as an ongoing, open-ended practice of inquiry. Post-process thought, on this account, is not a new theory of writing but a rejection of the possibility of any such theory.

4 Key Figures

4.1 Thomas Kent

Thomas Kent is the figure most directly responsible for giving post-process theory its name and its philosophical architecture. His work draws extensively on the philosophy of Donald Davidson and the tradition of hermeneutics to argue that communicative interaction is irreducibly paralogic—that is, it proceeds not by the application of codifiable rules but through contextual, probabilistic acts of interpretive guessing. Kent’s *Paralogic Rhetoric* (1993) and his edited collection (1999) remain the foundational texts of the movement.

4.2 Gary Olson

Gary Olson, writing from within the tradition of critical rhetoric, extended post-process critique into a broader interrogation of how authority and assertion function within academic discourse. Olson advocated for a mode of writing instruction that foregrounds how discourse constructs knowledge and power, rather than treating writing as a neutral skill to be transmitted from teacher to student. He called for the abandonment of what he termed the “rhetoric of assertion”—phallogocentric approaches that claim universal truths about writing—in favor of more exploratory, dialogic, and critically self-aware forms of composition.

4.3 Sidney Dobrin

Sidney Dobrin pushed the implications of post-process theory to their most radical conclusion in *Postcomposition* (2011), published by Southern Illinois University Press. Dobrin argued that composition studies should cease organizing itself around the figure of the student writer and the institutional imperatives of writing instruction, turning instead to the study of writing itself as a phenomenon. His work is discussed in greater detail in Section 7 below.

4.4 Lee-Ann Kastman Breuch

Lee-Ann Kastman Breuch made a crucial contribution to the pedagogical dimension of post-process theory in her 2002 article “Post-Process ‘Pedagogy’: A Philosophical Exercise,” published in *JAC: A Journal of Composition Theory*. Breuch argued that post-process theory should not be dismissed for its apparent antipathy toward classroom practice but should instead be understood as offering two guiding philosophical principles for instruction: the rejection of mastery and the engagement in dialogue rather than monologue with students. Her work represents the most sustained attempt to translate post-process philosophy into actionable pedagogical orientation.

5 The Critique of Process

A common misunderstanding of post-process theory is that it denies the existence of processes in writing. This is not the case. Post-process theorists readily acknowledge that writers engage in various activities—planning, drafting, revising, editing—that can be described as processes. What they reject is the reification of these activities into a singular, universally applicable “Writing Process” (capital W, capital P) that can be codified and taught as a transferable body of knowledge.

The distinction is between “process” as a lowercase descriptive heuristic and “Process” as an uppercase master narrative. The former is a useful shorthand for the observation that writing unfolds over time and involves recursive activities. The latter is an ideological construct that claims to have identified the essential structure of how all writing works and, on the basis of that claim, prescribes a standardized sequence of instructional activities. Post-process theory targets the latter while remaining largely agnostic about the former.

This critique has several dimensions. First, post-process theorists argue that the stages model of writing (prewriting, drafting, revising) has become overly rigid and universalized despite decades of empirical research demonstrating that actual writing practices are far more variable, recursive, and idiosyncratic than the model allows. Second, they contend that process pedagogy, by focusing on the composing behaviors of individual writers, neglects the social, institutional, and material conditions that shape writing. Third, and most fundamentally, they maintain that the very attempt to produce a general theory of composing is philosophically misguided, because writing is a situated, interpretive activity that cannot be reduced to rule-governed procedures.

Olson captured this point succinctly: to treat writing as a generalizable process is to attempt to systematize the unsystematizable. Joseph Petraglia similarly argued that treating writing as a teachable skill set represents a “losing proposition,” because whatever competencies students develop in one instructional context may not transfer to the radically different rhetorical situations they will encounter elsewhere.

6 Philosophical Foundations

The deepest philosophical roots of post-process theory lie in the work of the American philosopher Donald Davidson, particularly his account of communicative interaction. Davidson argued that successful communication does not depend on speakers and listeners sharing a fixed linguistic system—a “language” in the conventional sense—but rather on their ability to construct and revise interpretive frameworks in real time.

Davidson distinguished between *prior theories* and *passing theories*. A prior theory is the set of interpretive assumptions that a listener brings to a communicative encounter—expectations about what words mean, how sentences are structured, what the speaker is likely to intend. A passing theory is the interpretive framework that the listener actually employs in the moment of communication, adjusted on the fly in response to the specific utterances, contexts, and cues of the immediate situation. Communication succeeds when the passing theories of speaker and listener converge sufficiently, but this convergence is achieved not through the mechanical application of shared rules but through a dynamic, contextual process that Davidson acknowledged to be fundamentally “mysterious.”

Kent adopted Davidson’s framework as the basis for what he called *paralogic rhetoric*. The term “paralogic” signals that communicative interaction operates beyond (para-) the reach of formal logic or systematic codification. Writers, on this account, engage in a form of “hermeneutic guessing”—they draw on prior experience, cultural knowledge, and contextual cues to anticipate how their readers will interpret their texts, but this anticipation can never be reduced to a reliable algorithm. Every act of writing is, in this sense, a gamble on interpretation.

This philosophical orientation also draws on the broader hermeneutic tradition, particularly the work of Hans-Georg Gadamer, who argued that understanding is always a historically situated and dialogic process. For post-process theorists, writing is not the encoding of pre-existing meaning into textual form but an act of interpretation that is embedded in history, culture, and social relations. The writer does not transmit meaning to a reader; writer and reader co-construct meaning through an interpretive encounter that neither party fully controls.

7 Pedagogical Implications

If writing cannot be systematized, and if no generalizable writing process exists, then what becomes of writing instruction? This question has generated the most sustained debate within and around post-process theory.

Post-process theorists do not uniformly claim that writing “cannot be taught,” though this formulation is frequently attributed to them. The more nuanced position is that writing cannot

be taught in the way that process pedagogy assumes—that is, through the transmission of codifiable procedures and universally applicable strategies. What can be cultivated, however, are the dispositions, habits of mind, and situated practices that enable writers to navigate the inherently unpredictable terrain of communicative interaction.

Breuch identified two core principles for post-process pedagogy. The first is the *rejection of mastery*: writing instruction must abandon the pretense that it can equip students with a stable, transferable set of writing competencies. Writing is not a “thing” to be mastered but an activity to be practiced, and the conditions of that practice are always changing. The second principle is the *engagement in dialogue*: instruction should proceed not through monologic transmission of knowledge from teacher to student but through genuine dialogic exchange in which both parties participate as interpretive agents.

In practical terms, post-process pedagogy favors mentoring relationships over standardized curricula, situated practice over decontextualized exercises, and collaborative inquiry over prescriptive instruction. Breuch argued that “the strongest application of post-process theory is in the practice of one-to-one instruction that manifests itself in teacher-student interactions,” and she identified writing center tutorials as a particularly apt model for post-process pedagogy, since tutorials foreground the kind of collaborative, context-sensitive engagement that post-process theory values.

Other pedagogical implications include a shift from modeling techniques to fostering writer agency, an emphasis on critical literacy that examines how discourse constructs knowledge and power, and a reconceptualization of the teacher’s role from expert transmitter to co-participant in the interpretive process.

8 Sidney Dobrin’s Postcomposition

Sidney Dobrin’s *Postcomposition* (2011) represents the most radical extension of post-process thought. Where Kent and Olson challenged the process paradigm’s assumptions about writing, Dobrin challenged the very disciplinary identity of composition studies itself. His central argument is that the field has been fundamentally constrained by what he calls the “pedagogical imperative”—the assumption that the purpose of composition studies is, ultimately, to improve the teaching of writing to students.

Dobrin contends that this focus on the student writer and on institutional writing instruction has prevented the field from developing a genuinely theoretical understanding of writing as a phenomenon. Composition studies, in his account, has historically subordinated theory to practice, treating theoretical inquiry as valuable only insofar as it can be translated into classroom applications. This prohibition on theory, Dobrin argues, “greatly limits what can be understood about writing.”

Postcomposition calls for a fundamental reorientation of the field: away from the administration of writing students and toward the study of writing itself, understood through the lenses of ecocomposition, spatial theory, network theory, complexity theory, and systems theory. Dobrin also engages extensively with posthumanism, arguing that the field's understanding of subjectivity must be reworked in light of posthumanist critiques of the autonomous, rational human subject. The student writer, on Dobrin's account, is not a stable category around which a discipline can or should be organized; it is a contingent construction of institutional and ideological forces that postcomposition seeks to interrogate and move beyond.

Dobrin's work represents a provocation rather than a program. He explicitly cautioned against the temptation to "too hastily" translate post-process theoretical insights into practical pedagogical prescriptions, arguing that doing so would simply reproduce the instrumentalism that post-process theory was meant to challenge.

9 Criticisms

Post-process theory has attracted substantial criticism from multiple directions.

The most common objection is that post-process theory is *nihilistic about pedagogy*. If writing cannot be systematized, and if no generalizable composing process exists, then what exactly are writing teachers supposed to do? Critics charge that post-process theory, in its zeal to dismantle the process paradigm, offers nothing to replace it. Writing instructors who face classrooms of students with concrete writing assignments and institutional expectations cannot operate on the basis of philosophical skepticism alone. The claim that writing is irreducibly situated and interpretive may be philosophically interesting, but it provides little guidance for the practical work of writing instruction.

A related criticism is that post-process theory is *too abstract for classroom use*. Its philosophical foundations in Davidsonian hermeneutics and paralogic rhetoric are demanding even for specialists in rhetoric and composition, let alone for graduate teaching assistants or adjunct instructors staffing first-year writing courses. The gap between the theory's philosophical sophistication and the material realities of writing instruction is, for many critics, prohibitively wide.

A third and more pointed criticism is that post-process theory is *potentially elitist*. If writing cannot be taught systematically, then the students who benefit most from writing instruction are precisely those who arrive at the university already equipped with the cultural capital, linguistic resources, and prior literate experience that enable them to navigate complex rhetorical situations without explicit guidance. Students from marginalized backgrounds, who stand to gain the most from structured writing instruction, may be the ones most harmed by a pedagogical philosophy that rejects structured instruction as philosophically naive. This critique raises uncomfortable questions

about whose interests post-process theory serves and whose it neglects.

Finally, some critics have argued that the “post” in post-process is premature or misleading. Process pedagogy, they note, has always been more internally diverse and self-critical than post-process theorists acknowledge. Scholars such as Sondra Perl and Nancy Sommers had long recognized the recursive, messy, and context-dependent nature of composing processes without concluding that process pedagogy should be abandoned. The post-process critique, on this view, attacks a caricature of process theory rather than engaging with its most sophisticated formulations.

10 Legacy and Continuing Influence

Despite its name falling somewhat out of common usage—Kristopher Lotier has written of the “postprocess postmortem”—the intellectual legacy of post-process theory remains substantial. Its core insights have been absorbed into the broader disciplinary conversation of rhetoric and composition studies, shaping how scholars think about writing, pedagogy, and disciplinary identity even when the label “post-process” is not explicitly invoked.

Post-process theory’s insistence on the situated, social, and interpretive nature of writing contributed to the broader social turn in composition studies, reinforcing the influence of genre theory, activity theory, and rhetorical situation theory. Its skepticism toward universalizing claims about writing processes has informed the field’s growing interest in transfer studies, which investigate the conditions under which writing knowledge does or does not move across contexts.

More recently, post-process theory’s philosophical orientation has found resonance with *posthumanism* and *new materialism* in rhetoric and composition. Dobrin’s engagement with posthumanist subjectivity in *Postcomposition* anticipated a broader disciplinary turn toward questioning the centrality of the human subject in accounts of writing and meaning-making. New materialist scholars in rhetoric have drawn on post-process insights about the limits of systematization and the situatedness of communicative action while extending those insights into considerations of how nonhuman agents—technologies, environments, objects, biological systems—participate in the production of discourse. Kent’s concept of paralogic rhetoric has been explicitly connected to new materialist and multi-material approaches to composition that foreground the unpredictable entanglements of human and nonhuman actors in writing.

Post-process theory also contributed to the critical self-reflection that has characterized composition studies in the twenty-first century. By raising fundamental questions about whether writing can be taught, whether composition should be organized around pedagogy, and whether the discipline’s institutional structures serve its intellectual aspirations, post-process theorists opened a space for the kind of disciplinary interrogation that continues to animate debates about the future of writing studies.

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